And, yes, it's weird. I'm used to being on set with 100 people, lights buzzing, walkie-talkies crackling, chai being passed around. Now I'm sitting in a quiet room with my laptop, asking a machine to imagine a car chase in the Himalayas, without ever touching a camera. It's bizarre. But strange isn't always bad.

What I'm learning is that AI doesn't replace creativity, it just challenges our orthodox definitions of it. It gives you options, sometimes too many at once. It speeds things up. It lets you experiment with ideas you wouldn't otherwise have the budget for. But it doesn't give you meaning. It doesn't know why that character needs to pause before answering.

It won't tell you when to linger in silence, or when a glance says more than dialogue. That's still on us, and I think it always will be. The fear that AI will replace storytellers is real, but in most cases, it'll just reveal who actually has something to say and who is relying on style passing off as substance.

No Need For a Crew

The most exciting part of AI, especially for Indian filmmakers, is access. The ability to start. To build a mood board, previsualise a sequence, test an idea without waiting for a studio to greenlight your pitch. This could genuinely democratise filmmaking. I've seen young storytellers already using these tools to shape their voice in new ways. It's exciting, it's raw and it's scrappy in the best possible way. The flip side? We're going to get flooded with content that looks good but says nothing. Most call it 'AI slop': competent visuals, generic emotion, no soul. The challenge is going to be separating signal from noise, craft from output.

Another tricky bit: most of these tools are trained on global (read: western) data. That means early outputs often don't reflect Indian faces, bodies, textures and rhythms. A lot of what I saw in early tests felt... off. Like watching a Hindi scene filtered through a Scandinavian art film. But that's not a reason to opt out. If we don't shape these tools, they won't reflect us. Indian filmmakers, artists, designers—all of us need to be part of the training process, which includes feeding data from our films and stories. Only that will shape a more authentic output. That's the only way these tools will evolve to handle our visual language, our emotional logic.

The Ethical Questions

Recently, there was that whole thing about an AI-generated alternate ending to *Raanjhanaa*. It raised some real questions: can people just remix someone else's film? Who owns that version? And what happens when a machine starts rewriting our past? I don't think that's the future we want. At Jouska, my studio, we've been exploring AI workflows, but we're also asking the hard questions: where are the ethical lines? Who gets credit? What's fair use, and what's theft in disguise? If this is going to grow, we need thoughtful guardrails that protect creativity without killing experimentation.

Where does that leave us? I don't have all the answers. I'm figuring it out as I go. Some days I'm excited by the possibilities, some days I just miss the messiness of a real shoot. But I do believe this: I'm going to just try to stay curious about what's possible in storytelling. In the end, the story still matters. The emotion still matters. And as long as we keep that at the centre, I think we'll find ways to use these tools not to replace the magic of cinema but to find new spells we didn't know we could cast. ■

Shakun Batra is the Founder of Jouska Films and the director of Gehraiyaan *(2022),* Kapoor & Sons *(2016) and* Ek Main Aur Ekk Tu *(2012)*

TAKEAWAYS

- **AI won't replace creativity, it will expand horizons, allow experimentation and democratise filmmaking**
- **Since most tools are trained on western data, Indian filmmakers will have to step in to evolve our visual language**
- **Copyright dilemmas are crucial to address, with guardrails that protect creativity without killing experimentation**

WHAT AI WON'T TELL YOU IS WHEN TO LINGER IN SILENCE, WHEN A GLANCE CAN SAY MORE THAN WORDS. THAT'S STILL ON US, AND I THINK IT ALWAYS WILL BE. WE HAVE TO **SEPARATE SIGNAL FROM NOISE, CRAFT FROM OUTPUT**